last years battling the persecution of the petty hypocrites who had turned on him. So he stayed away, and passed away in exile.

Delhi High Court Justice Sanjay Kishan Kaul (later elevated to the Supreme Court) authored a magisterial judgment in 2007 disposing of several of these cases in a learned, closely-argued and meticulously-footnoted ruling that bears detailed reading and extensive citation.[19] Recalling the richness of India's 5,000-year-old culture, the judge noted:

> 'Ancient Indian art has been never been devoid of eroticism where sex worship and graphical representation of the union between man and woman has been a recurring feature. The sculpture on the earliest temples of (the) Mithuna image or the erotic couples in Bhubaneshwar, Konark and Puri in Orissa (150–1250 CE); Khajuraho in Madhya Pradesh (900–1050 CE); Limbojimata temple at Delmel, Mehsana (tenth century CE); Kupgallu Hill, Bellary, Madras; and Nilkantha temple at Sunak near Baroda [are fine examples of this]… Even the very concept of (the) "lingam" of the God Shiva resting in the centre of the yoni, is in a way representation of the act of creation, the union of Prakriti and Purusha. The ultimate essence of a work of ancient Indian erotic art has been religious in character and can be enunciated as a state of heightened delight or ananda, the kind of bliss that can be experienced only by the spirit.'

But Husain's tormentors seemed to know nothing of these ancient Hindu traditions; instead, they professed to be defending their idea of the Hindu faith and the nation's cultural integrity. (In objecting to his use of nudity, they were in fact being far more Puritan, in the Christian sense of the term, than Hindu.) Instead of applauding the decision of a Muslim artist to derive inspiration from the ancient legends of his homeland, they accused him of desecrating a faith that was not his. Instead of honouring an artist who had revived worldwide appreciation of the richness and diversity of the sources of Indian culture, they attacked him for insulting Indian culture, reducing Indianness to the narrow bigotry of their own blinkers.

It is a disgrace that India allowed the most intolerant elements of its society to derail the life and work of such a great artist. These so-called Hindus had clearly never seen the inside of any of our ancient temples, had never marvelled at Khajuraho or seen a sunset at Konark. Theirs is a notion of 'Bharatiya Sanskriti' that is profoundly inauthentic, because it can be traced back no further than the Puritanism that accompanied the Muslim conquests.